

The Saracoff Sentinel

TEAM TIJUANA

FALL 2005

Sometimes a letter from a visitor can explain things better than we can. The following words from a Canadian teen will give you a glimpse into what short-term teams have done recently. It's also an invitation for you or your church to come help us.

Jacqueline's Letter—

If two years ago you would have told me that 19 people including myself would put our own lives on hold to head to Mexico for 10 days to share God's love with the locals, I would have said you were crazy—but now I can't wait to go and do it again. As part of the senior high youth group of Airdrie Alliance Church in nice and cold Alberta Canada, I was given the opportunity to go to the ends of the earth with some amazing people and give the less fortunate a chance to see the love that placed Jesus Christ upon the cross. Coming from a place where we take almost everything in life for granted and going to a place where we didn't even have a warm shower, drinkable tap water or a mirror brought on a little culture shock.

Our missions trip team was given the chance to go to a drug rehab center, do mimes and clown skits for vacation Bible school, run basketball camps, rebuild a rickety set of stairs, lay floors and do a VBS carnival. We also had the opportunity to help poor families in need and build some amazing relationships—despite the fact that we didn't speak much Spanish. In reality we were given a chance to share what God has blessed us with and learn the power of faith and how to serve. As much as you want to take care of people, you can only do so much. The only thing you have power in is your prayer and God will handle the rest.

We all fell in love with the people and culture. Saying goodbye was heartbreaking. But if there was one thing we learned from people in Mexico, it was to have faith...they know how to rely on God for food and shelter—to have faith even in hard times—and to serve with an open and willing heart, giving God the glory. I would give up all my possessions to have the faith that the people who served us have. They have true servanthood. So as we all miss the Mexican culture, the kids we played with, the warm weather and the family next door who cooked wonderful food for us, we hold these lessons in our hearts...our prayers are with you.

Held in his hands,

Jacqueline Sarah Cromwell



Tacos, face-painting,
playing and sharing
build great memories



Jacqueline



Micro Enterprise Development

Wouldn't it be better to help poor people start simple businesses than have them always dependent on charity? Of course, not all the poor are capable of doing their own business, but statistics worldwide show that the poor would rather work than receive hand-outs and that a surprising number, driven by the needs of their children, can succeed if given a chance. No one fits the pattern better than the poor mother with five children whose husband has just died or disappeared.

It is true that women in these situations, particularly where abuse is involved, need charity and strong helping hands those first months to get back on their feet. But when does charity stop and self-reliance start? Not that any of us are truly self-dependent, but we know that women who are given charity indefinitely have the joy and respect that hard work brings taken from them. Like the jungle cats who are fed at the zoo, they may not be able to return to their natural habitat.

In short, Team Tijuana is trying to give loans to single mothers and needy men so that they can start their own business. These are very small business situations—selling tacos, baking cakes, selling clothes, cutting hair and giving perms—etc. We'll teach them how to handle money, market their product or service, deal with conflicts, and improve parenting skills. We are using a model that has been successful worldwide (95% loan repayments). They'll go through six loan cycles in two years (16 wk each). Each cycle, they will receive a larger loan since they were responsible in paying back the previous one.

Not only is there a business side to Micro Enterprise Development (MED), but there is a personal and spiritual side of this program also. Since the women have no collateral for their loans, they are formed into groups of 20 which meets weekly. Each of the twenty agrees to pay their own loan payment plus make up any missed payment by any fellow members. Consequently, the group is very careful to let only honest, hard-working people into their group, also known as a "*community bank*." Two other benefits are that these groups become support groups for the members. Single mothers who had no one to trust before can now trust and be trusted by the group. The second benefit is a spiritual one. We can start Bible studies in these groups. No one is required to be a Christian, but it is common for these groups to accept Bible studies and the values that come with them. Some groups can even be the start of a new church.

We are praying that we will have the \$6000 to start the first two groups (20 people in each) by the end of October. We believe that when others see the success of this program, they will help us with the additional \$30,000 to continue these groups and start some "incubator" businesses to help the drug rehab and the other ministries. Money donated for relief is much needed but when women who have been down-trodden are ready to face the world, we need to give them more—a chance to work. Please pray for this new venture.

Greg and Kathy



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Please indicate:
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